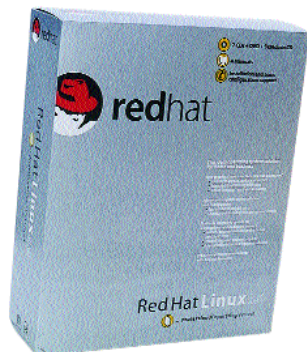


Red Hat 8.0

Hat full of goodies

A first look, Red Hat 8.0 might fool a Red Hat user into thinking that it's a brand new distribution. The graphics have changed quite a bit, and the images and characters look clear and bold. This new look has been dubbed by Red Hat as 'Blue Curve'.



Looks aside, version 8.0 offers several enhanced features. For instance, there's a new option to check the installation medium for problems just before installation begins—quite a thoughtful addition given that less-than-flawless installations are a sure-shot recipe for disaster in Linux.

A new installation type, called Personal Desktop, has also been added. This is in addition to the usual Workstation, Server and Custom installation types. The package selection and installation has been given a new look and has been grouped into five categories: Desktop, Applications, Servers, Development and System. The Desktop group contains KDE and Gnome, the Application group contains various editors, calculators, games and applications. The Servers group contains FTP, DNS, SAMBA and other protocol servers, while the Development group has compilers and several Software Development Kits (SDKs). When you choose the installation type,

packages pertaining to it are selected by default.

A standard Personal Desktop installation consists of 369 basic packages (these are non-deselectable components) plus 132 additional packages such as Gnome, games, etc. This installation type will need 1,558 MB of space and takes about 20 minutes to install. A Complete Personal Desktop, with all the packages, takes 4,680 MB of hard disk space and 50 minutes to install. These times were logged on a system using the Intel 1.7 GHz CPU, Intel D845GBV motherboard, 256 MB DDR (266 MHz) RAM, nVidia GeForce2 Ultra graphics accelerator, a 40 GB Seagate Barracuda hard disk and a 48x LG CD drive. Since a majority of potential Linux users may not have such a high system configuration, installation times can be expected to be significantly longer.

The Boot Loader Configurator, which sets up your system to boot Linux or shares it with other OSes, has upgraded features. You can now specify the boot sequence (for example: CD-ROM first, then floppy, then hard disk). For a single-boot system (only Linux), installation is quite simple but for a dual-boot system (say, Linux and Windows), experience in creating and assigning partitions is required.

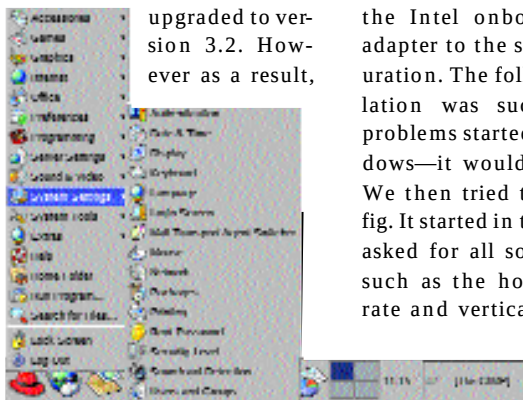
The first time Red Hat starts, a new agent activates itself and configures system date, time and sound settings. The Setup Agent also helps in installing any other packages from the additional CDs.

Red Hat 8.0 also has a better control panel—the entire menu structure is well-organised. Repetition, an essential element of user-friendliness, has been achieved by making

the same configuration tools appear again and again under different headings.

Integration is another user-friendly design aspect. Red Hat integrates some applications such as Open Office 1.0, Mozilla Open Source Browser and Ximian Evolution (an e-mail client, calendar and contact manager, all in one) as part of the installation process. It provides an alternative to Star Office with the Open Office package.

The most important feature for developers, the GNU Compiler Collection (GCC), has also been upgraded to version 3.2. However as a result,



The Red Hat 8.0 features a neat and clean new interface

the GNU C++ compiler has some compatibility issues over the type of object code it produces. GCJ (GNU Compiler for Java) has been upgraded, as also the GDB (GNU DeBugger). The C and C++ libraries have also been enhanced and the overall compiler performance has been improved.

The bundled MP3 players present in version 7.3, mpg123 and XMMS, are not included in version 8.0 due to

patenting issues, this causes a major setback in the multimedia performance. It also lacks some games that were present in the older version.

In order to see just how Red Hat 8.0 performs under 'stress' tests such as hardware changes (this has always been a thorny issue in previous versions), we decided to change some hardware. The Intel motherboard used in the test bed had an onboard GPU, so we decided to remove the GeForce2 card. When we started the machine, Linux properly detected the change and prompted us to remove the GeForce drivers and add the Intel onboard graphics adapter to the system configuration. The following installation was successful. The problems started with X-Windows—it wouldn't initialise. We then tried the XF86Config. It started in text mode and asked for all sorts of details such as the horizontal scan rate and vertical refresh rate and so on.

Even after giving all the details, X - W i n - d o w s wouldn't start. This is one area where the user-friendliness needs to be enhanced.

Overall, Red Hat 8.0 promises to be pretty good but if something fails, it's quite difficult to amend things.

SPECIFICATIONS

System requirements:

Pentium-class CPU or better, at least 650 MB hard disk space, 128 MB RAM

Red Hat 8.0		B
Performance	►►►►►►►►	
Ease of use	►►►►►►►►	
Value for money	►►►►►►►►	
Features	►►►►►►►►	
OVERALL	►►►►►►►►	